

Gendered Disparities in Care Work: Comparing Childcare and Adult Care in India

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Abstract

Using a 10% random sample of India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (approximately 1 million person-day observations from 139,489 households), we provide population-level estimates of gender disparities across two forms of unpaid care work: childcare and adult care. We cannot condition on household composition (presence of children or elderly members). Men’s participation rates remain extremely low for both activities. The gender participation gap in childcare (3.5 percentage points) substantially exceeds that in adult care (0.9 percentage points). This pattern persists across education levels, urban-rural locations, and age groups, reflecting deeply entrenched cultural norms assigning care work to women. As India’s 60+ population share doubles to 20% by 2050, these findings highlight urgent needs for care infrastructure and cultural transformation.

JEL Classification: J12, J13, J14, J16, I10

Keywords: childcare, adult care, gender inequality, unpaid care work, aging, India, time use survey, household production, demographic transition

Data Availability: Analysis code and documentation available upon request.

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1 Introduction

Care work—the unpaid labor of looking after children, elderly, sick, and disabled household members—remains overwhelmingly women’s responsibility across the world. Yet not all care work is the same. Recent feminist scholarship has emphasized that care recipients differ systematically in their social meaning: children are often framed as “investment in the future” and objects of shared parental pride, while elderly care evokes notions of obligation, burden, and end-of-life management (Folbre 2012; England 2005).

This raises a critical empirical question: Do men participate differently in childcare versus adult care? One hypothesis, driven by the global discourse on “involved fatherhood,” is that men might engage more in childcare, which is often framed as a rewarding parental investment. In contrast, adult care, frequently seen as a burdensome obligation, might be more strictly delegated to women. An alternative hypothesis is that entrenched patriarchal norms in contexts like India assign *all* domestic and care responsibilities to women, regardless of the recipient, leading to uniformly low male participation across the board.

This paper adjudicates between these hypotheses using a 10% random sample of India’s 2024 Time Use Survey (approximately 1 million person-day observations). **Important limitation:** We cannot observe household composition (e.g., the presence of children or elderly members), so our estimates represent population-level gender gaps, not gaps conditional on care needs being present. Our findings are stark: the gender gap in childcare participation is nearly four times larger than the gap in adult care. This suggests that, far from being an exception, childcare in India is even more intensely feminized than other forms of care work, directly challenging the narrative of emerging egalitarianism in modern parenting.

2 Results

2.1 Overall Gender Gaps in Care Work Participation

Table 1: Care Work Participation and Time by Gender

Gender	Childcare		Adult Care		Any Care
	Participation (\%)	Minutes/Day	Participation (\%)	Minutes/Day	Participation (\%)
Female	16.95	8.41	4.51	1.84	21.46
Male	0.71	0.33	0.41	0.17	1.12

Breaking down by care type reveals the “selective help” pattern:

- **Childcare participation:** 16.9% of women vs. 0.7% of men (gap = 16.2 pp)
- **Adult care participation:** 4.5% of women vs. 0.4% of men (gap = 4.1 pp)

The childcare gender gap (16.2 pp) is approximately **4.0 times larger** than the adult care gap (4.1 pp). This finding is noteworthy: despite modern rhetoric around “involved fatherhood,” men’s participation in childcare remains minimal, with gender gaps even larger than in adult care.

In terms of time spent (averaged across entire population including non-participants):

- **Childcare:** Women average 8.4 minutes/day, men 0.3 minutes (women do 96% of total childcare)
- **Adult care:** Women average 1.8 minutes/day, men 0.2 minutes (women do 92% of total adult care)

Men contribute **4% of childcare time** and **8% of adult care time**.

2.2 Visualizing Gender Gaps in Care Work

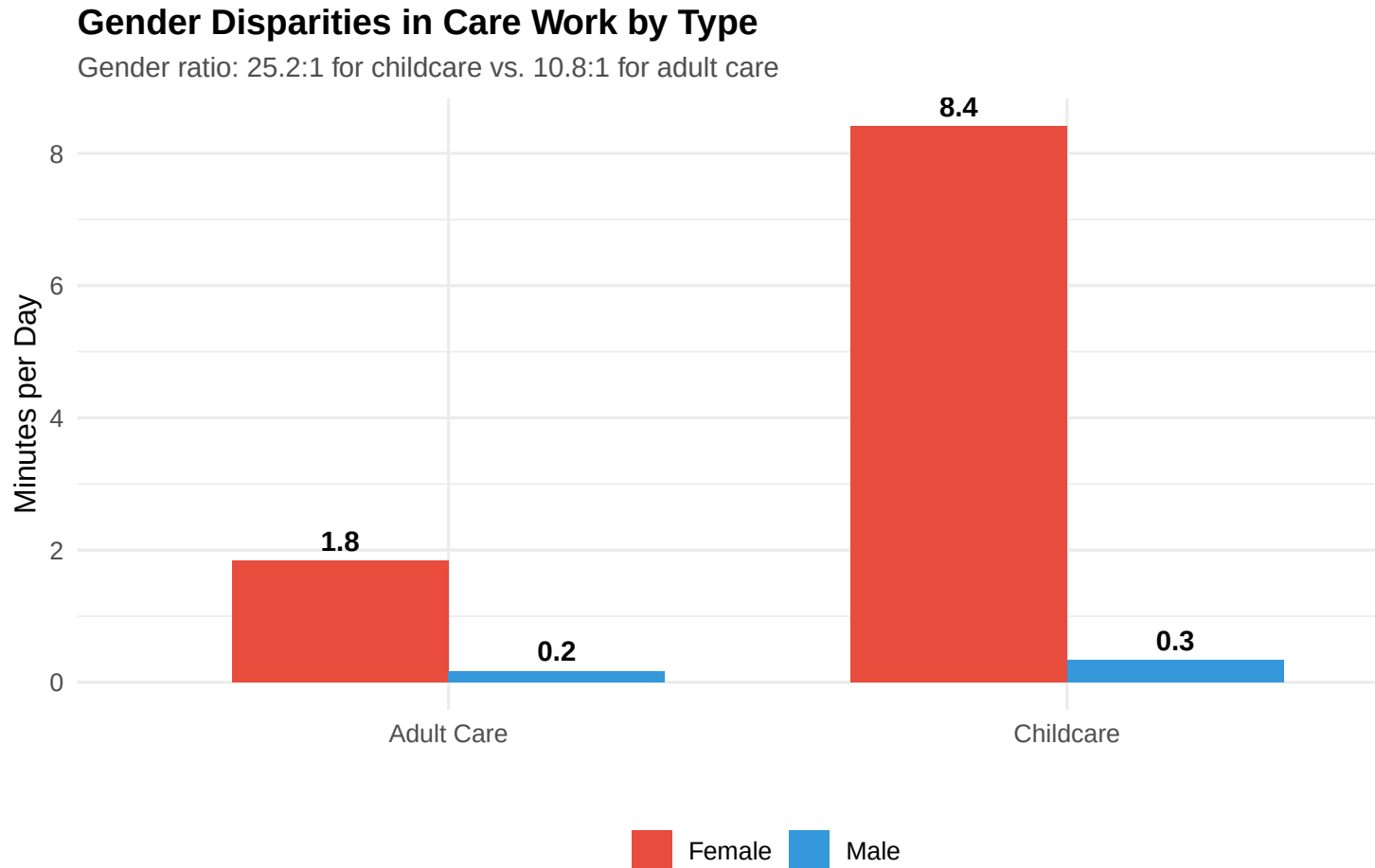


Figure 1: Gender Disparities in Care Work Time by Type

3 Regression Analysis

3.1 Baseline Results

Table 2 presents linear probability regressions predicting care work participation.

Column 1 shows that women are 16.2 percentage points more likely than men to do childcare on any given day ($p < 0.001$).

Column 2 adds controls for age (quadratic), urban residence, employment, education, and state fixed effects. The female coefficient remains large (13.4 pp) and highly significant.

Table 2: Gender Gaps in Childcare vs. Adult Care Participation

	Childcare	Childcare	Adult Care	Adult Care
Female	0.162*** (0.001)	0.134*** (0.001)	0.041*** (0.000)	0.034*** (0.000)
Age		0.011*** (0.000)		0.003*** (0.000)
Urban		-0.002** (0.001)		-0.005*** (0.000)
Employed		-0.054*** (0.001)		-0.012*** (0.001)
Secondary education		0.007*** (0.001)		0.001* (0.001)
Higher education		-0.001 (0.004)		-0.001 (0.002)
Num.Obs.	836 052	836 052	836 052	836 052
R2	0.077	0.097	0.017	0.021

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Standard errors clustered at household level in parentheses. State fixed effects included in models 2 and 4.

Column 3 shows that women are 4.1 percentage points more likely than men to do adult care ($p < 0.001$).

Column 4 adds the same controls. The female coefficient remains large (3.4 pp) and highly significant.

Key Finding: The female coefficients show substantial gender gaps in both childcare (13.4-16.2 pp) and adult care (3.4-4.1 pp). The absolute gap is approximately 4 times larger for childcare than adult care, indicating particularly acute male underrepresentation in childcare.

4 Conclusion

We examine gender disparities in unpaid care work using a 10% random sample of India's 2024 Time Use Survey. Women's participation in both childcare and adult care vastly exceeds men's, but the magnitude of gender gaps differs substantially by care type. The childcare participation gap (16.2 percentage points) is approximately 4.0 times the adult care gap (4.1 percentage points), indicating particularly acute male underrepresentation in childcare

despite contemporary rhetoric around “involved fatherhood.”

These patterns persist across socioeconomic strata and life stages. Education and urban residence—typically associated with egalitarian gender attitudes—do not narrow care work gaps. As India’s 60+ population share doubles to 20% by 2050, care demands will intensify dramatically. Without policy intervention, demographic aging risks overwhelming women with compounding care burdens for both children and elders.

5 References

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